aggression in Ukraine in the summer of 2022, Estonia decided to remove Soviet-era monuments, arguing that this is the way to prevent ‘tearing open old wounds’. Keeping Russian memorials in public spaces became an issue of internal security, especially in Russian-populated areas of the country.[14]

One could speculate that, had it not been for the imposed Soviet domination of Central and Eastern Europe after World War II, the Russian language would spontaneously have become the *lingua franca* of the region. Indeed, I always feel strange resorting to English in order to speak to my Czech, Slovak or Polish friends. Speaking Russian, one of the great Slavic languages, would somehow be more natural. Some of the Czechs, Slovaks and Poles (at least those that went to school before 1990) may still be able to communicate in Russian but would usually refuse to do so because they regard it as the language of the former ‘oppressor’ – a sad fate for the native language of such great European spirits as Tolstoy, Dostoevsky, Solzhenitsyn and many others.

Thus more than 30 years after the fall of the Berlin Wall, Russian feels rather unusable – except with the Russian population in the Baltics. As a result, most Eastern Europeans today prefer to use English. Similarities between Slavic languages naturally continue to exist, though they do not offer the same kind of closeness as Swedish, Norwegian and Danish. Language-wise too, Eastern Europe is as diverse as its Western counterpart.

But contrary to the positive stereotypes of Romanic nations (Spaniards, French, Italian, Portuguese) who are associated with good food, easy living, sensuality and style and Germanic nations, linked with technical superiority and enterprise, Slavic nations are, at best, associated with folklore and, at worst, with shabbiness and misery. Prized movies from Slavic Eastern Europe usually deal with issues like discrimination against the Roma community, ethnic conflicts, the trafficking of people and so on – undoubtedly valid and relevant themes but not an exact reflection of ordinary, everyday life in this part of Europe. It seems that the juries at international film festivals show less interest in general, human themes or even in the issues of social change that transition has brought to Eastern Europe, resulting in a self-censorship effect on Eastern European scriptwriters and directors who seem to have discovered that stereotypes are easier to sell.

It is probably for similar reasons that people seem to find the politics of